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Assessing security of service provider computing systems

Abstract

This disclosure describes techniques that include assessing whether various service providers, such as cloud service providers or SaaS providers, are properly maintaining sensitive data (e.g., private, confidential, and/or non-public information) that is entrusted to them. In one example, this disclosure describes a method that includes collecting, by a computing system, information about interactions with a service provider computing system; identifying, based on the information about the interactions, a plurality of network paths, each associated with a data object accessed at the service provider computing system; requesting, based on the plurality of network paths, data from the service provider computing system; receiving a response; determining, based on the response, whether the response includes sensitive information; and taking action based on whether the response includes sensitive data.

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Background/Summary

TECHNICAL FIELD

(1) This disclosure relates to computer networks, and more specifically, to evaluating data management practices of service providers.

BACKGROUND

(2) Cloud computing is the delivery of computing services over a network, often the internet. Service providers offering services through the cloud are sometimes referred to as software as a service (“SaaS”) providers. Such SaaS providers tend to offer services to its customers (“clients”) in a way that provides convenience, fast innovation, flexible resources, and economies of scale. While there are many types of cloud services available on the internet, typically such services involve operating on, analyzing, and/or storing client data on computing systems that are outside the client's own private network, and on computing systems that the client does not own or fully control.

SUMMARY

(3) This disclosure describes techniques that include assessing whether service providers, such as cloud computing-based service providers or SaaS providers, are properly maintaining sensitive data (e.g., private, confidential, and/or non-public information) that is entrusted to them by clients.

Clients of SaaS providers may transmit sensitive data to SaaS providers for the purpose of enabling the SaaS provider to provide a specific service (e.g., storage, encryption, analysis). Sensitive data can take many forms, but often such data is private, confidential, and/or otherwise non-public data, at least from the perspective of the client.

(4) In some examples, techniques described herein include assembling a list of network paths or data locations associated with (or potentially associated with) data maintained by a SaaS provider in a cloud computing system. The list of paths may be created, in an automated way, based on available network information. Once the list is created, each network path or data location on the list is assessed to determine whether data can be accessed from that location without authentication or any special access rights. If data can be accessed, the data is evaluated to determine whether it includes sensitive data. If the data does include sensitive data or indicia of sensitive data, a computing system may take action in response. Such actions may involve communications and alerts sent to various stakeholders, which may include the organization affected by the open disclosure of sensitive data, clients of the service provider, and/or the service provider. Other actions may involve restricting or limiting interactions with the service provider, or restricting or limiting storage of data at computing systems managed by the storage provider.

(5) The techniques described herein may provide certain technical advantages. For instance, in some examples, a computing system may be able to generate a list of network paths or URLs that correspond to locations at which a given SaaS provider stores data. In such an example, the computing system may generate the list of network paths in an automated way based on network information available on the client's own network, and in so doing, gain insights and potentially determines a pattern for how data is typically stored at various cloud service providers. Such processes may be performed with little or no manual curation or reverse engineering of the storage practices or the structure of the network paths for various SaaS providers. Further, by systematically accessing data at service providers, a comprehensive and ongoing evaluation of data practices employed by a large number of service providers may be obtained, which enables actions to be taken where appropriate, and on a timely basis. Since early notice may be taken of SaaS providers that fail to employ appropriate or sufficient data management practices, effective remediation actions can be taken. As a result, client data entrusted to SaaS providers is more likely to be kept private, secure, and confidential.

(6) In some examples, this disclosure describes operations performed by a computing system or collection of computing systems in accordance with one or more aspects of this disclosure. In one specific example, this disclosure describes a method comprising collecting, by a computing system, information about interactions with a service provider computing system, wherein the interactions with the service provider computing system are based on activity of user devices on a private network; identifying, by the computing system and based on the information about the interactions, a plurality of network paths, each associated with a data object accessed at the service provider computing system; requesting, based on the plurality of network paths, data from the service provider computing system; responsive to requesting the data, receiving, by the computing system, a response; determining, by the computing system and based on the response, whether the response includes sensitive information; and taking action by the computing system and based on whether the response includes sensitive data.

(7) In another example, this disclosure describes a system comprising an analysis computing system and a collection computing system, wherein the analysis computing system is on a private network, and the collection computing system is not on the private network, and wherein the analysis computing system is configured to carry out operations described herein. In yet another example, this disclosure describes a computer-readable storage medium comprising instructions that, when executed, configure processing circuitry of a computing system to carry out operations described herein.

Description

BRIEF DESCRIPTION OF THE DRAWINGS

- (1) FIG. 1 is a conceptual diagram illustrating an example system in which the data maintenance and/or management practices of various service provider systems are evaluated, in accordance with one or more aspects of the present disclosure.
- (2) FIG. 2 is a block diagram illustrating an example system in which the data maintenance and/or management practices of various service provider systems are evaluated, in accordance with one or more aspects of the present disclosure.
- (3) FIG. 3 is a conceptual diagram illustrating a process for automatically generating a manageable subset of path data that can be used to analyze data maintenance and/or management practices employed by various service provider systems, in accordance with one or more aspects of the present disclosure.
- (4) FIG. 4 is a flow diagram illustrating operations performed by an example assessment computing system in accordance with one or more aspects of the present disclosure.

DETAILED DESCRIPTION

- (5) Described herein are techniques that include testing whether “Software as a Service” (SaaS) websites are missing security controls, and in particular, are exposing sensitive data to public disclosure. Sensitive data or information may include any information that can be characterized as private, confidential, and/or otherwise non-public. Businesses and other organizations routinely use services provided by third-party SaaS providers, and in the process, provide sensitive information or documents to such SaaS websites, expecting that the SaaS provider will maintain the confidentiality of the information. However, such SaaS providers might nevertheless fail to protect sensitive information and documents, and in some cases, may inadvertently make such data openly available on the internet. Techniques described herein seek to identify instances in which a SaaS provider is failing to adequately protect confidential information entrusted to it by the provider's customers.
- (6) For large organizations, monitoring practices of the SaaS providers used by members or employees of the organization can be a difficult task. Some large organizations may use, partner with, do business with, and/or otherwise interact with thousands of SaaS vendors. Typically, the identity of such vendors than an organization depends on continually evolves, with new SaaS vendors being added frequently. For many organizations, oversight of its SaaS partners is insufficient.
- (7) FIG. 1 is a conceptual diagram illustrating an example system in which the data maintenance practices of various service provider systems are evaluated, in accordance with one or more aspects of the present disclosure. In FIG. 1, system **100** includes two networks: private network **101** and public network **150**. Devices connected to private network **101** may be part of a secure network not normally accessible to the public, such as an enterprise network, organizational network, or local area network. In some examples, devices and/or computing systems on private network **101** may be considered to be on enterprise network **102**, which may be controlled and/or operated by a business enterprise or other organization. Although private network **101** and/or enterprise network **102** may be principally located within one location, private network **101** and/or enterprise network **102** may also be geographically distributed across multiple locations.
- (8) A number of devices and/or systems are shown connected to private network **101** and part of enterprise network **102** in FIG. 1. Such devices and systems include user devices **103A**, **103B**, through **103M** (collectively, “user devices **103**”), one or more content systems **104**, and one or more cloud access security broker systems **108**. Each of user devices **103** each may be any suitable computing device capable of being operated by a user (not shown). Such user devices **103** may include mobile devices, tablets, laptop computers, desktop computers, workstations, or any other

suitable computing device. Typically, each of user devices **103** is capable of accessing other computing systems within private network **101** and outside of private network **101** (e.g., through public network **150**). For instance, one or more of user devices **103** may interact with, over public network **150**, one or more of service provider systems **190A**, **190B**, through **190N** (collectively “service provider systems **190**,” and representing any number of service provider systems).

(9) One or more content systems **104** may be used to store content pertaining to an organization or business that might use or control enterprise network **102**. Such content may include records, network logs, session logs, or other information. Content systems **104** may store other information as well. One or more content systems **104** may also be or include application servers and other systems that support operations and perform processing work on behalf of one or more of user devices **103**.

(10) One or more cloud access security broker systems **108** may monitor or regulate communications between private network **101** and public network **150**. In such an example, one or more cloud access security broker systems **108** may serve as an intermediary or proxy between user devices **103** and public network **150** and systems available over public network **150** (e.g., service provider systems **190**). One or more of cloud access security broker systems **108** may enable private network **101** and enterprise network **102** to implement policies that apply to interactions by user devices **103** with other devices on public network **150**. In so doing, one or more of cloud access security broker systems **108** may play a role in securing private network **101** and/or enterprise network **102** by addressing gaps in security when user devices **103** interact with devices (e.g., service provider systems **190**) outside of private network **101**. In some examples, one or more of user devices **103** may send requests to cloud access security broker system **108**, which evaluates the requests, and then carries out operations on public network **150** as appropriate or consistent with policies implemented at cloud access security broker system **108** and/or within enterprise network **102**. One or more cloud access security broker systems **108** may log information about sessions between various user devices **103** and service provider systems **190**. Such information may include session data, proxy log data, and other information.

(11) For ease of illustration, one cloud access security broker system **108** and one content system **104** are illustrated as included within private network **101** and enterprise network **102**. In other examples, any number of cloud access security broker systems **108** and any number of content systems **104** may be included within private network **101** and/or enterprise network **102**. Further, one or more of cloud access security broker systems **108** and content systems **104** may themselves be deployed within a public or private cloud setting or through a service provider. In such examples, one or more cloud access security broker systems **108** and/or content systems **104** might not be logically or physically within enterprise network **102**.

(12) Private network **101** may include various other network devices, as is typical of a network. Although not shown, such devices may include one or more network hubs, network switches, network routers, satellite dishes, or any other network equipment. Such devices or components may be operatively inter-coupled, thereby providing for the exchange of information between computers, devices, or other components (e.g., between one or more client devices or systems and one or more server devices or systems).

(13) Public network **150** may be primarily described as a public network, such as the internet. However, techniques in accordance with one or more aspects of the present disclosure may apply to similar systems in which network **150** is implemented as a private network. As with private network **101**, public network **150** may include other network devices not specifically illustrated in FIG. 1, such as one or more network hubs, network switches, network routers, satellite dishes, or any other network equipment.

(14) Public network **150** may be used by user devices **103** within enterprise network **102** to access computing systems operated by various SaaS providers. Such computing systems are illustrated in FIG. 1 as service provider systems **190**. Each of service provider systems **190** may be used to

implement or provide a different service, and each may be operated by a different entity.

Accordingly, each of service provider systems **190** may employ different practices to manage data entrusted to each respective service provider system **190** by clients or customers.

(15) Clients or customers as described herein may be an organization or business, such as the organization or business that uses or controls enterprise network **102**. Users within an organization or business (e.g., users operating user devices **103**) may access one or more of service provider systems **190** over public network **150**. Such access may be regulated to some extent by one or more cloud access security broker systems **108** or by proxy servers within enterprise networks **102**.

Consumers or individuals (e.g., operating consumer device **113**) may also be clients or customers of one or more of service provider systems **190**.

(16) Typically, the nature of the service provided by a given SaaS provider, as implemented by a given service provider system **190**, tends to involve clients and organizations providing or sending data to the service provider system **190**. In some cases, the data provided to the service provider system **190** includes sensitive information, and is provided to the service provider system **190** by clients having an expectation that the sensitive information will be appropriately protected and/or kept confidential. In general, therefore, each of service provider systems **190** is likely to be entrusted with a significant amount of sensitive data from its clients or customers, where such clients or customers regard such data as private, confidential, and otherwise non-public. At least some of the techniques described herein are intended to evaluate the extent to which each of service provider systems **190** succeeds in appropriately protecting and/or maintaining its clients' and customers' sensitive data.

(17) Assessment computing system **110** is illustrated in FIG. **1** as including both analysis computing system **120** and collection computing system **170**. Analysis computing system **120**, as described herein, may perform operations that include analysis of communications between user devices **103** and service provider systems **190**, and interacting with collection computing system **170** to evaluate data maintenance practices and other practices of one or more service provider systems **190**. Collection computing system **170**, also as described herein, may perform operations that include interacting with one or more of service provider systems **190** in an attempt to access data stored at service provider systems **190**, and then assessing whether such data includes information that might be characterized as private, sensitive, confidential, and/or otherwise non-public. As described herein, collection computing system **170** may report its findings to analysis computing system **120**, and analysis computing system **120** may act on the findings as appropriate.

(18) In some examples, it may be appropriate for certain operations performed by assessment computing system **110** to be carried out within enterprise network **102**, whereas other operations performed by assessment computing system **110** may be more appropriately performed outside of enterprise network **102**, such as on a computing device having no special access rights to any of service provider systems **190**. Accordingly, assessment computing system **110** may be implemented through a distributed system that includes multiple computing systems, such as analysis computing system **120** (logically or physically located within enterprise network **102**) and collection computing system **170** (logically or physically located outside of enterprise network **102**). Other implementations are possible, however, and in some examples, operations described herein as being performed by analysis computing system **120** may be performed by a system outside of enterprise network **102**. Likewise, in some examples, operations described herein as being performed by collection computing system **170** may be performed by a system inside of enterprise network **102**.

(19) For ease of illustration, one enterprise network **102** is shown in FIG. **1**, which may correspond to a single organization or business. However, techniques described herein may be applicable and employed by many organizations and enterprise networks **102**. In addition, techniques described herein may be provided as a service to multiple organizations, consumers, or other entities.

(20) In FIG. **1**, and in accordance with one or more aspects of the present disclosure, assessment

computing system **110** may identify one or more of service provider systems **190**. For instance, in an example that can be described in the context of FIG. **1**, analysis computing system **120** of assessment computing system **110** outputs a signal over private network **101**. Cloud access security broker system **108** and/or content system **104** detect a signal and determine that the signal corresponds to a request for information about interactions between user devices **103** and service provider systems **190**. Cloud access security broker system **108** and/or content system **104** output a responsive signal over private network **101**. Analysis computing system **120** detects a signal over private network **101** and determines that the signal includes a list of SaaS providers (each operating one of service provider systems **190**) along with information about interactions between user devices **103** and service provider systems **190**.

(21) Assessment computing system **110** may filter the SaaS providers to limit the scope of analysis to be undertaken. For instance, still referring to FIG. **1**, analysis computing system **120** uses the information about interactions to identify those SaaS providers where a minimum or threshold amount of traffic has been exchanged between user devices **103** and that SaaS provider's corresponding service provider system **190**. Analysis computing system **120** may also use the information about interactions to identify unique network path information. Such network path information may take the form of a uniform resource locator (URL) or uniform resource identifier (URI). Analysis computing system **120** may also, based on certain attributes of the interactions between user devices **103** and service provider systems **190**, identify network paths that are may be more likely to correspond locations at which a SaaS provider may store files, objects, documents, or other data that may include sensitive information. In doing so, analysis computing system **120** may analyze stem and object information included within URLs, such as in the manner described in connection with FIG. **3**. Analysis computing system **120** generates a list of identified URLs based on its analysis of the information about interactions.

(22) Assessment computing system **110** may attempt to retrieve data at the identified URLs. For instance, again referring to FIG. **1**, analysis computing system **120** outputs a signal over private network **101** and public network **150**. Collection computing system **170** detects a signal over public network **150** and determines that the signal includes the list of identified URLs. Collection computing system **170** uses the list of identified URLs to systematically attempt to access data at one or more of service provider systems **190**. Collection computing systems **170** outputs a series of requests **188** (e.g., requests **188A** through **188N**) and in response, receives a series of responses **182**.

(23) In the example being described, collection computing system **170** may issue requests for data with the access rights of an anonymous computing device that merely has access to public network **150**. In other words, when seeking to access data at one or more of service provider systems **190**, collection computing system **170** might not provide any authentication credentials to any of service provider systems **190**. Collection computing system **170** may, in some examples, simulate how a hacker or a malicious user might seek to obtain sensitive data.

(24) Assessment computing system **110** may analyze responses **182** for sensitive data. For instance, collection computing systems **170** applies a machine learning model to any data included within responses **182**. In some examples, such a machine learning model has been trained to identify sensitive information from data, such as data that might be included within responses **182**. Collection computing system **170** identifies instances where one or more of service provider systems **190** have responded to a request sent by collection computing system **170** by including sensitive data.

(25) Analysis computing system **120** may act on the evaluations performed by collection computing system **170**. For instance, in FIG. **1**, collection computing system **170** reports information about its evaluation to analysis computing system **120** (e.g., over public network **150** and private network **101**). Analysis computing system **120** takes action based on the reporting information received from collection computing system **170**. In some examples, analysis

computing system **120** may interact with cloud access security broker system **108** to modify or implement policies enforced by cloud access security broker system **108** within private network **101** and enterprise network **102**. In some examples, such policies may prevent further instances of sensitive data (i.e., private, confidential, or otherwise non-public information) being made available publicly on one or more of service provider systems **190**.

(26) The techniques described herein may provide certain technical advantages. Analyses performed by assessment computing system **110** may provide insights into how data is stored at various service provider systems **190**. Such analyses may be performed, in some cases, with little or no manual assembly of URLs or reverse engineering of network paths to be evaluated by collection computing system **170** of assessment computing system **110**. Further, by systematically accessing data at service provider systems **190**, a proactive, comprehensive, and ongoing evaluation of a large number of service provider systems **190** is possible. Such an evaluation may enable early action to be taken to address or prevent data from being stored at service provider systems **190** that might not have in place proper controls for maintaining the private or confidential data. As a result, assessment computing system **110** may enable or increase the odds that client data (e.g., data generated by or used by one or more user devices **103**) will be kept private, secure, and confidential.

(27) FIG. 2 is a block diagram illustrating an example system in which the data maintenance practices of various service provider systems are evaluated, in accordance with one or more aspects of the present disclosure. FIG. 2 illustrates system **200**, which may be similar to system **100** of FIG. 1, and may be considered an example or alternative implementation of aspects of system **100** of FIG. 1. In the example of FIG. 2, system **200** includes many of the same elements described in FIG. 1, and elements illustrated in FIG. 2 may correspond to earlier-illustrated elements that are identified by like-numbered reference numerals. For example, private network **101** and public network **150** of FIG. 2 may correspond to private network **101** and public network **150** of FIG. 1, respectively. Similarly, analysis computing system **120** and collection computing system **170** may correspond to those same components of assessment computing system **110** of FIG. 1. In general, these like-numbered elements and others may represent previously-described elements in a manner consistent with prior descriptions provided in connection with the description of FIG. 1.

(28) In FIG. 2, analysis computing system **120** is illustrated as including underlying physical compute hardware that includes power source **121**, one or more processors **123**, one or more communication units **125**, one or more input devices **126**, one or more output devices **127**, and one or more storage devices **130**. Storage devices **130** may include path analysis module **131**, training module **133**, remediation module **135**, and data store **139**. Stored within storage device **130** may also be path data **136**, training data **137**, and one or more models **138**. One or more of the devices, modules, storage areas, or other components of analysis computing system **120** may be interconnected to enable inter-component communications (physically, communicatively, and/or operatively). In some examples, such connectivity may be provided by through communication channels, which may include a system bus (e.g., communication channel **122**), a network connection, an inter-process communication data structure, or any other method for communicating data.

(29) Power source **121** of analysis computing system **120** may provide power to one or more components of analysis computing system **120**. One or more processors **123** of analysis computing system **120** may implement functionality and/or execute instructions associated with analysis computing system **120** or associated with one or more modules illustrated herein and/or described below. One or more processors **123** may be, may be part of, and/or may include processing circuitry that performs operations in accordance with one or more aspects of the present disclosure. One or more communication units **125** of analysis computing system **120** may communicate with devices external to analysis computing system **120** by transmitting and/or receiving data, and may operate, in some respects, as both an input device and an output device. In some or all cases,

communication unit **125** may communicate with other devices or computing systems over private network **101**, public network **150**, or over other networks.

(30) One or more input devices **126** may represent any input devices of analysis computing system **120** not otherwise separately described herein, and one or more output devices **127** may represent any output devices of analysis computing systems **150** not otherwise separately described herein. Input devices **126** and/or output devices **127** may generate, receive, and/or process output from any type of device capable of outputting information to a human or machine. For example, one or more input devices **126** may generate, receive, and/or process input in the form of electrical, physical, audio, image, and/or visual input (e.g., peripheral device, keyboard, microphone, camera). Correspondingly, one or more output devices **127** may generate, receive, and/or process output in the form of electrical and/or physical output (e.g., peripheral device, actuator).

(31) One or more storage devices **130** within analysis computing system **120** may store information for processing during operation of analysis computing system **120**. Storage devices **130** may store program instructions and/or data associated with one or more of the modules described in accordance with one or more aspects of this disclosure. One or more processors **123** and one or more storage devices **130** may provide an operating environment or platform for such modules, which may be implemented as software, but may in some examples include any combination of hardware, firmware, and software. One or more processors **123** may execute instructions and one or more storage devices **130** may store instructions and/or data of one or more modules. The combination of processors **123** and storage devices **130** may retrieve, store, and/or execute the instructions and/or data of one or more applications, modules, or software. Processors **123** and/or storage devices **130** may also be operably coupled to one or more other software and/or hardware components, including, but not limited to, one or more of the components of analysis computing system **120** and/or one or more devices or systems illustrated or described as being connected to analysis computing system **120**.

(32) Path analysis module **131** may perform functions relating to evaluating session or proxy log information to extract URLs or other information relating to communications between storage devices **130** and service provider systems **190**. Training module **133** may perform function relating to training, using machine learning techniques, one or more models **138**. Remediation module **135** may perform functions relating to acting on analyses performed by collection computing system **170** pertaining to data maintenance practices of various service provider systems **190**. Such actions may include reporting on results of such analyses or interacting with cloud access security broker system **108** or another system to configure, restrict, or otherwise regulate access to service provider systems **190** by user devices **103**.

(33) Data store **139** may represent any suitable data structure or storage medium for storing information related to operations performed by analysis computing system **120**. The information stored in data store **139** may be searchable and/or categorized such that one or more modules within analysis computing system **120** (e.g., path analysis module **131**, training module **133**, remediation module **135**) may provide an input requesting information from data store **139**, and in response to the input, receive information stored within data store **139**. Data store **139** may be primarily maintained by path analysis module **131**.

(34) In the example of FIG. 2, collection computing system **170** is also illustrated as including underlying physical hardware. Such hardware may include power source **171**, one or more processors **173**, one or more communication units **175**, one or more input devices **176**, one or more output devices **177**, and one or more storage devices **180**. These components may be implemented or may correspond to similar components described elsewhere herein (e.g., as with respect to analysis computing system **120**). For example, power source **171** may provide power to one or more components of collection computing system **170**. One or more processors **173** may implement functionality and/or execute instructions associated with collection computing system **170** or associated with one or more modules of collection computing system **170**. One or more

communication units **175** of collection computing system **170** may communicate with devices external to collection computing system **170** by transmitting and/or receiving data over a network or otherwise. One or more input devices **176** and output devices **177** may generate, receive, and/or process input and output, respectively. One or more storage devices **180** may store program instructions and/or data associated with one or more of the modules of storage devices **180** in accordance with one or more aspects of this disclosure.

(35) Storage devices **180** may store program code for collection module **181**, analysis module **183**, reporting module **185**, and data store **189**. Storage device **180** may also store other information, including path data **186**, one or more responses **182**, and one or more production models **187**.

(36) Collection module **181** may perform functions relating to collecting (or attempting to collect) data (e.g., through requests **188**) from service provider systems **190** using path data **186**. Analysis module **183** may perform functions relating to analyzing any responses **182** received from service provider systems **190** as a result of attempts to collect data from service provider systems **190**.

Reporting module **185** may perform functions relating to communicating with other computing devices and systems (including, but not limited to analysis computing system **120**) about analyses performed by analysis module **183**. Such communications may include reports about the extent to which private, sensitive, confidential, or otherwise non-public information can be accessed at one or more service provider systems **190**.

(37) Data store **189** may represent any suitable data structure or storage medium for storing information related to operations performed by collection computing system **170**. The information stored in data store **189** may be searchable and/or categorized such that one or more modules within collection computing system **170** may provide an input requesting information from data store **189**, and in response to the input, receive information stored within data store **189**. Data store **189** may be primarily maintained by collection module **181**.

(38) In FIG. 2, and in accordance with one or more aspects of the present disclosure, one or more of user devices **103** may interact with one or more of service provider systems **190**. For instance, in an example that can be described in the context of FIG. 2, user device **103A** outputs a signal over private network **101**. Private network **101** routes the signal over public network **150**. Service provider system **190A** detects the signal and determines that the signal originated from user device **103A**. User device **103A** and service provider system **190A** further communicate over private network **101** and public network **150**. As a result of the communication, and in the process of service provider system **190A** providing services to user device **103A**, user device **103A** may store data at service provider system **190A**. In some cases, the data stored at service provider system **190A** may be data that a user of user device **103A** regards as sensitive (e.g., private, confidential, or otherwise non-public). Similarly, one or more other user devices **103** may communicate with service provider system **190A** or other service provider systems **190** over private network **101** and public network **150**. Such communications by user devices **103** may similarly involve data being transferred from user devices **103** to one or more of service provider systems **190**. Again, and in general, data stored by user devices **103** at service provider systems **190** may be regarded by users of user devices **103** (or the organization associated with enterprise network **102**) as including sensitive data.

(39) Cloud access security broker system **108** may monitor interactions between user devices **103** and service provider systems **190**. For instance, continuing with the example being described in connection with FIG. 2, cloud access security broker system **108** may monitor interactions and/or other communications between user devices **103** and service provider systems **190** by observing signals on connection **107**. In such an example, cloud access security broker system **108** collects information about the interactions observed on connection **107** (see the arrow from connection **107** to cloud access security broker system **108** in FIG. 2, intended to represent monitoring of relevant network connections by cloud access security broker system **108**).

(40) Cloud access security broker system **108** may log information about the interactions. For

instance, in FIG. 2, cloud access security broker system **108** outputs a signal over private network **101**. Content system **104** detects a signal over private network **101** and determines that the signal corresponds to information about interactions observed by cloud access security broker system **108** between user devices **103** and service provider systems **190** on private network **101** (e.g., based on monitoring connection **107**). Content system **104** stores information about the interactions in log data store **105**. In some examples, the information about the interactions may include information that may be present in session logs or proxy logs maintained by cloud access security broker system **108** and/or content system **104**. Such information may include URLs, URIs, server names, document names, URI and/or URL stems and objects, protocols, and other information. In some examples, such information may also include information about the time at which objects were accessed or stored at various service provider systems **190**, information about authentication procedures employed by service provider systems **190**, information derived from the content of the data accessed at or stored at service provider systems **190**, or other information.

(41) In the example being described, information about interactions between user devices **103** and service provider systems **190** is described as being transferred to content system **104** for storage at content system **104**. In other examples, however, such interaction information may be stored elsewhere, including within cloud access security broker system **108**, or at another system inside of enterprise network **102** or outside of enterprise network **102** (e.g., at a cloud-based system). Further, in some examples, cloud access security broker system **108** may serve as a direct intermediary between user devices **103** (or private network **101**) and service provider systems **190**. In such an example, cloud access security broker system **108** may apply security, content, or other policies of the organization associated with private network **101**. Such policies may involve limiting access to one or more of service provider systems **190** or providing services designed to prevent data loss, control operations that may be permitted, detect security or malware threats, perform encryption and other services.

(42) Analysis computing system **120** may analyze interactions between user devices **103** and service provider systems **190**. For instance, again with reference to the example being described in connection with FIG. 2, path analysis module **131** of analysis computing system **120** causes communication unit **125** of analysis computing system **120** to output a signal over private network **101**. Content system **104** detects a signal over private network **101** and determines that the signal corresponds to a request for information about interactions between user devices **103** and service provider systems **190**. Content system **104** accesses information within log data store **105**. Content system **104** outputs a signal over private network **101**. Communication unit **125** of analysis computing system **120** detects a signal and outputs information about the signal to path analysis module **131**. Path analysis module **131** determines that the signal includes information about interactions between storage devices **130** and service provider systems **190**, including URIs or URLs associated with data accessed or stored by user devices **103** at service provider systems **190**. Path analysis module **131** stores the information as path data **136**. Path analysis module **131** analyzes path data **136**, such as by parsing the URLs included within into stems and objects, as described in connection with FIG. 3. Path analysis module **131** identifies URLs and other path data that would be appropriate or effective to use in assessing whether sensitive data stored at one or more service provider systems **190** is being properly maintained by such service provider systems **190**. In some examples, path analysis module **131** may select a subset of path data **136** for further analysis.

(43) Analysis computing system **120** may communicate information about its analysis to collection computing system **170**. For instance, still with reference to FIG. 2, path analysis module **131** causes communication unit **125** to output a signal over private network **101** and public network **150**. Communication unit **175** of collection computing system **170** detects a signal and outputs information about the signal to collection module **181**. Collection module **181** determines that the signal includes path information, URLs, and/or related information associated with data stored at

one or more of service provider systems **190**. In some examples, the path information received by collection computing system **170** may be the subset of path data **136** selected by analysis computing system **120**. Collection module **181** stores the information received from analysis computing system **120** as path data **186**.

(44) Collection computing system **170** may initiate requests for data at one or more of service provider systems **190**. For instance, again with reference to FIG. 2, analysis computing system **120** outputs a signal over private network **101** and public network **150** destined for collection computing system **170**. Collection module **181** of collection computing system **170** receives information about the signal and interprets the signal as a command to initiate an analysis of the data management practices of one or more service provider systems **190**. In response, collection module **181** evaluates path data **186** and identifies URLs or creates URLs that might be associated with publicly accessible data at one or more of service provider systems **190**. Collection module **181** causes communication unit **175** to output a series of signals over public network **150**. One or more of service provider systems **190** detect the signals over public network **150** and determine that the each of the signals correspond to a request **188** for a specific data object, web page, or other item of data stored at a respective service provider system **190**. Each of service provider systems **190** respond to such requests by outputting a corresponding response **182**.

(45) Specifically, and as illustrated in FIG. 2, service provider system **190A** may receive request **188A**, and in response, service provider system **190A** may output response **182A** to collection computing system **170** over public network **150**. Similarly, service provider system **190B** may receive request **188B**, and in response, service provider system **190B** may output response **182B** to collection computing system **170** over public network **150**. And in general, service provider system **190N** may receive request **188N** and respond by outputting response **182N** to collection computing system **170** over public network **150**.

(46) Note that in the example being described, collection computing system **170** might not provide (and might not possess) authentication credentials associated with any of service provider systems **190**. In most examples, collection computing system **170** seeks to simulate the network posture of a hacker or a malicious user that might not have any special access or authentication credentials. Accordingly, collection computing system **170** might not use any authentication data, but collection computing system **170** might also be located outside of enterprise network **102**, since its presence inside of enterprise network **102** (e.g., having an address associated with private network **101**) might also confer certain access not otherwise available to a hacker or anonymous public user. In general, therefore, collection computing system **170** may seek to access sensitive information that may be published by one or more service provider systems **190** without appropriate controls. As such, collection computing system **170** may issue requests for data with the access rights of an anonymous computing device that merely has access to public network **150**.

(47) Collection computing system **170** may collect responses to requests **188**. For instance, still referring to FIG. 2, communication unit **175** of collection computing system **170** detects a series of signals over public network **150**. Communication unit **175** outputs information about the signal to collection module **181**. Collection module **181** determines that the signals correspond to responses **182** (i.e., response **182A** through response **182N**). Collection module **181** stores responses **182** within storage device **180**. Collection module **181** may also store information derived from responses **182** within data store **189**.

(48) Collection computing system **170** may analyze responses **182**. For instance, again with reference to FIG. 2, collection module **181** outputs information about the responses **182** to analysis module **183**. Analysis module **183** evaluates the information and determines whether any of responses **182** contain any meaningful data. In some cases, one or more responses **182** may contain data, but such data might not be meaningful. For example, if a specific request, such as request **188A**, is denied by service provider system **190A** for lack of authentication (e.g., service provider system **190A** requires authentication to access data specified by request **188A**), then response **182A**

may contain data that simply reports that access to the underlying data object has been denied. However, in such an example, response **182A** might not contain any meaningful data that is susceptible to analysis for the presence of sensitive data. Similarly, if response **182A** to request **188A** includes encrypted data, or data that is otherwise not susceptible to a sensitivity analysis (e.g., certain binary or non-text data), then response **182A** might not be considered to include any meaningful data. For those requests **188** that do not result in a response **182** having meaningful data, analysis module **183** might conclude that no sensitive data is present, and might not undertake any further analysis for that request and response. In such examples, analysis module **183** may conclude that any sensitive data (e.g., private, confidential, or otherwise non-public data) that might be stored at the URL specified by such requests **188** is properly maintained and/or protected by the corresponding service provider system **190**.

(49) Collection computing system **170** may analyze responses **182** that do contain data. For instance, again referring to FIG. 2, analysis module **183** may determine that some of responses **182** include data that can be analyzed for the presence of sensitive information. In such examples, analysis module **183** may perform a further analysis of responses **182**, which may involve analysis of any textual data included within a given response **182**. In such an example, analysis module **183** analyzes the text included within a given response **182** for indicia or attributes of sensitive, private, confidential, or otherwise non-public information. Analysis module **183** may, for example, seek to identify text included within responses **182** having branding-related strings or similar information that suggests that sensitive information is present. For example, if businesses named “XYZ, Inc.” or “ABC Corporation” are known to exist (e.g., if XYZ, Inc. operates enterprise network **102**), analysis module **183** may evaluate whether a given response **182** includes a string of text having some form of the words “XYZ Confidential,” “XYZ Restricted,” “ABC Confidential,” “ABC Restricted” or the like. If analysis module **183** identifies the presence of such a string within a response **182**, then analysis module **183** may conclude that that response **182** includes sensitive information.

(50) Similarly, certain sensitive information may have a known form, and a response **182** that includes data in such a form might represent sensitive data. For instance, a text string having the form “nnn-nn-nnnn,” where each “n” character is a numeric digit, may represent a social security number, which is typically considered sensitive information. In another example, text strings which have some resemblance to known words, but that include other characters or seemingly random characters, might represent strings used for passwords (e.g., “Beagle1234”). If analysis module **183** determines that a specific response **182** includes a listing of such words, perhaps along with a corresponding list of email addresses (or usernames), analysis module **183** may conclude that that response **182** includes sensitive information.

(51) Analysis module **183** may analyze all parts of any documents or other data objects included within responses **182**, including not just the body of the document, but also headers, footers, watermarks, and metadata. Analysis module **183** might also evaluate responses **182** for the presence of data or strings that tend to indicate that the data does not include sensitive data. For example, if a response **182** includes a string such as “XYZ Public” or “ABC Public,” that would tend to indicate that the response **182** does not contain sensitive data. In another example, analysis module **183** might also determine that a given response **182** includes data presented in a public setting (e.g., a slide deck for a known public presentation), or information that is known to already be public information (e.g., a restaurant menu, information matching news reporting, information otherwise publicly available elsewhere). To the extent that analysis module **183** identifies the presence of such text in a given response **182**, analysis module **183** may conclude that that response **182** does not include sensitive information.

(52) To perform the analysis on responses **182**, analysis module **183** may apply a machine learning model (e.g., production model **187**) that has been trained to distinguish between responses **182** that include sensitive information and responses **182** that do not include sensitive information. In some

examples, production model **187** may be deployed on collection computing system **170**, but the underlying data used to train production model **187** might not be stored on collection computing system **170**.

(53) Training production model **187** typically involves use of a training data that includes at least some sensitive, private, confidential, or otherwise non-public information. It may therefore be important to ensure that production model **187** is trained in a location (e.g., within enterprise network **102**) where such training data can be reliably kept confidential. Once trained, however, applying the model to new data often does not require use of the sensitive training data, so deploying production model **187** at a location outside of enterprise network **102** might not place sensitive information at risk of disclosure. Accordingly, while a machine learning model could be trained by collection computing system **170**, it may be preferable to train such a model on a computing system that may be better protected than collection computing system **170**. In some examples, analysis computing system **120** is used to train one or more models **138** to distinguish between responses **182** having sensitive data and responses **182** that do not. Production model **187** may be selected from or based on such models **138**.

(54) In an example where analysis computing system **120** is used to train one or more machine learning models **138**, analysis computing system **120** may collect training data for use in such training. For instance, and again with reference to FIG. 2, training module **133** of analysis computing system **120** causes communication unit **125** to output a series of signals over private network **101**. Various systems within private network **101** (e.g., one or more content systems **104**) detect one or more of the signals and determine that the signals correspond to requests for training data that can be used to train models **138**. Communication unit **125** of analysis computing system **120** detects a series of responsive signals and outputs information about the signals to training module **133**. Training module **133** determines that the signals include training data or data that can be used for training data. Training module **133** stores such information within storage device **130** or within data store **139** as training data **137**.

(55) Training data **137** may represent a set of documents and other data objects, some of which include sensitive information, and some of which do not. Training data **137** may include a corresponding desired output value associated with each data object that enables training module **133** to apply supervised learning techniques to train one or more models **138**. Once trained, models **138** are capable of making a prediction about whether a data object includes sensitive information. Training data **137** (including data objects that have sensitive information and those that do not) may be derived from ordinary business records maintained by the systems on private network **101**. Training data **137** may also include information monitored or observed by cloud access security broker system **108** being communicated to or from one or more of service provider systems **190** or other external systems accessible over public network **150**. Training data **137** may also include third party information or manually curated information based on actual or simulated business records or documents. Such manually curated information may also include data derived from interactions observed by cloud access security broker system **108**. Such manually curated information may also include information derived from actual responses **182** obtained during prior analyses of service provider systems **190**, where such responses **182** have been manually evaluated (or reevaluated) for the presence of sensitive data. Such information may be used for training or retraining one or more models **138** (and production model **187**) as part of an ongoing effort to improve the skill of such models **138**.

(56) Analysis computing system **120** may train one or more models **138**. For instance, again referring to FIG. 2, training module **133** accesses training data **137** and applies one or more machine learning algorithms to develop models or parameters for models that can be used to predict whether a given set of information (e.g., one or more responses **182**) include sensitive information (i.e., private, confidential, or otherwise non-public information). Training module **133** generates one or more models **138** and stores models **138** within storage device **130**. In some

examples, one or more of models **138** may generate a scoring rubric in order to determine the potential or likelihood that sensitive data (i.e., private, confidential, or otherwise non-public information) or data is included in a given set of data object or response **182**.

(57) Analysis computing system **120** may deploy one or more models **138** to collection computing system **170**. For instance, referring to FIG. 2, training module **133** of analysis computing system **120** causes communication unit **125** to output a signal over private network **101** and public network **150**. Communication unit **175** of collection computing system **170** detects a signal over public network **150** and outputs information about the signal to analysis module **183**. Analysis module **183** determines that the signal includes one or more machine learning models that can be used to identify sensitive information included within responses **182**. Analysis module **183** stores at least one of the machine learning models within storage device **180** as production model **187**. Thereafter, when analysis module **183** assesses one or more responses **182** for sensitive information, analysis module **183** applies production model **187** to generate a prediction. The prediction is used by analysis module **183** to determine whether a specific response **182** includes sensitive information.

(58) In some examples, when analysis module **183** applies production model **187**, production model **187** may generate an output in the form of one of a finite number of categories, representing a likelihood that a given response **182** includes sensitive information. In one example, a production model **187** may indicate that information or data within a given response **182** falls within one of three categories: “high watermark,” “medium watermark,” or “low watermark.”

(59) Where production model **187** indicates a “high watermark,” production model **187** has assessed that data included within a given response **182** likely includes sensitive information. Where a given response **182** is categorized as “high watermark,” information about the underlying response **182** might be passed to a remediation team for further analysis (e.g., possibly involving actions to remove the sensitive data from the offending service provider system **190**).

(60) Production model **187** may categorize a response **182** in the “low watermark” category where the response **182** has been assessed as having no sensitive data (e.g., no private, confidential, or otherwise non-public information). In some examples, a path or URL corresponding to a response **182** categorized in the “low watermark” category might be marked as benign, thereby signaling to collection computing system **170** that it might not be necessary to reevaluate the URL for a period of time within a finite window (e.g., 30-60 days).

(61) For responses **182** that production model **187** categorizes in the “medium watermark” category, information about such responses **182** may be communicated to a team of data analysts (e.g., within enterprise networks **102**) for further analysis. In some examples, such an analysis may be used to generate additional training data **137**. Such additional training data **137** may later be used by training module **133** to retrain and potentially improve the skill of one or more of models **138**. One or more of such improved models **138** may eventually be deployed to collection computing system **170** for use as a new production model **187**.

(62) Collection computing system **170** may report information about the analysis of responses **182**. For instance, referring again to FIG. 2, analysis module **183** of collection computing system **170** outputs information about the analysis performed by analysis module **183** (and production model **187**) to reporting module **185**. Reporting module **185** evaluates the information and determines whether and to what extent collection computing system **170** should communicate with other systems about the analyses performed. Reporting module **185** causes communication unit **175** to output a series of signals over public network **150** and private network **101**. Communication unit **125** of analysis computing system **120** detects signals over private network **101** and outputs information about the signals to remediation module **135**. Remediation module **135** determines that the signals correspond to reporting of results of the analysis performed by collection computing system **170**.

(63) Analysis computing system **120** may take action in response to the reporting by collection computing system **170**. For instance, remediation module **135** of analysis computing system **120**

uses the reporting information received from collection computing system **170** to identify instances in which one or more of service provider systems **190** seem to be making sensitive information publicly available on public network **150**. Remediation module **135** takes action in response to identifying such instances, such as by modifying policies employed within enterprise network **102** of private network **101**. In such an example, analysis computing system **120** may communicate with cloud access security broker system **108** over private network **101** and reconfigure and/or adjust whether or how cloud access security broker system **108** monitors, regulates, and/or controls access to one or more service provider systems **190**. In some examples, such adjustments may involve restricting the types of data that can be exchanged between user devices **103** and service provider systems **190**. Alternatively, or in addition, such adjustments may involve limiting access by one or more of user devices **103** to specific service provider systems **190** (e.g., those service provider systems **190** that are not sufficiently safeguarding private, sensitive, and/or confidential information). Alternatively, or in addition, such adjustments may also involve blocking all access to one or more of service provider systems **190**.

(64) In some examples, actions taken by analysis computing system **120** may include communicating with one or more devices operated by users, administrators, or SaaS providers. Such communications could provide alerts to administrators or security personnel overseeing enterprise network **102**, thereby enabling action to be taken to secure information or remediate any information breaches. Such communications could also involve alerts or notifications being sent to users of user devices **103** within enterprise network **102**. Such communications could also take the form of an attempt to notify each service provider system **190** that appears to be employing faulty or problematic data privacy practices. Such communications may have the effect of causing modifications to the faulty or problematic data privacy policies employed and/or implemented by various service provider systems **190**. If such modifications are made and are successful, analysis computing system **120** may modify or lift any restrictions previously made in response to reporting by collection computing system **170**.

(65) Modules illustrated in FIG. 2 (e.g., path analysis module **131**, training module **133**, remediation module **135**, collection module **181**, analysis module **183**, reporting module **185**, and potentially others) and/or illustrated or described elsewhere in this disclosure may perform operations described using software, hardware, firmware, or a mixture of hardware, software, and firmware residing in and/or executing at one or more computing devices. For example, a computing device may execute one or more of such modules with multiple processors or multiple devices. A computing device may execute one or more of such modules as a virtual machine executing on underlying hardware. One or more of such modules may execute as one or more services of an operating system or computing platform. One or more of such modules may execute as one or more executable programs at an application layer of a computing platform. In other examples, functionality provided by a module could be implemented by a dedicated hardware device.

(66) Although certain modules, data stores, components, programs, executables, data items, functional units, and/or other items included within one or more storage devices may be illustrated separately, one or more of such items could be combined and operate as a single module, component, program, executable, data item, or functional unit. For example, one or more modules or data stores may be combined or partially combined so that they operate or provide functionality as a single module. Further, one or more modules may interact with and/or operate in conjunction with one another so that, for example, one module acts as a service or an extension of another module. Also, each module, data store, component, program, executable, data item, functional unit, or other item illustrated within a storage device may include multiple components, sub-components, modules, sub-modules, data stores, and/or other components or modules or data stores not illustrated.

(67) Further, each module, data store, component, program, executable, data item, functional unit, or other item illustrated within a storage device may be implemented in various ways. For example,

each module, data store, component, program, executable, data item, functional unit, or other item illustrated within a storage device may be implemented as a downloadable or pre-installed application or “app.” In other examples, each module, data store, component, program, executable, data item, functional unit, or other item illustrated within a storage device may be implemented as part of an operating system executed on a computing device.

(68) FIG. 3 is a conceptual diagram illustrating a process for automatically generating a manageable subset of path data that can be used to analyze data management practices employed by various service provider systems, in accordance with one or more aspects of the present disclosure. FIG. 3 includes a flow diagram (301-305) illustrating a process by which analysis computing system 120 analyzes interactions between user devices 103 and service provider systems 190, and performs actions based on such analysis. The interactions between user devices 103 and 190 can be characterized by certain URL or URI information, illustrated in FIG. 3 as URL data 310A and URL data 310B. Analysis computing system 120 may construct table 330 in order to filter or choose a subset of the URLs to use in evaluating one or more of service provider systems 190. Generally, table 330 can be used to effectively limit the volume of URLs to be processes or analyzed. Table 330 may also be used to deduce URL patterns relating to how one or more service provider systems 190 store data. As described herein, collection computing system 170 uses information derived from URL data (e.g., URL data 310A and URL data 310B) in order to interact with service provider systems 190 in an attempt to determine whether such service provider systems 190 are safeguarding data that has been entrusted to them.

(69) In the process illustrated in FIG. 3, and in accordance with one or more aspects of the present disclosure, analysis computing system 120 may identify a list of sanctioned SaaS providers (301). For instance, in an example that can be described with reference to FIG. 1 and FIG. 3, analysis computing system 120 outputs a signal over private network 101 to cloud access security broker system 108. Cloud access security broker system 108 detects the signal and determines that it corresponds to a request for a list of approved SaaS providers (each of which may operate one of service provider systems 190). Cloud access security broker system 108 outputs a responsive signal over private network 101. Analysis computing system 120 detects the signal and determines that the signal includes a list of approved SaaS providers, and may include information (e.g., addresses, domain names) about corresponding service provider systems 190. The list of approved SaaS providers identifies those SaaS providers that are approved for use by users of enterprise network 102 (e.g., users of devices 103 on private network 101). There may be tens of thousands of SaaS providers, so there may be value in limiting the scope of any analysis performed by assessment computing system 110. While it may be appropriate to evaluate even those SaaS providers that are not approved or being used by users of enterprise network 102, it may be appropriate to limit any such analysis to just those SaaS providers approved by use by a given organization, such as an organization that administers enterprise network 102. Such filtering may have the effect of limiting the scope of an analysis undertaken by assessment computing system 110 to a manageable size.

(70) Analysis computing system 120 may, from the list of sanctioned SaaS providers, identify SaaS providers having traffic that exceeds a data threshold (302). For instance, still referring to FIG. 1 and FIG. 3, analysis computing system 120 filters the list of SaaS providers to include those where the amount of traffic exchanged between each such SaaS site (i.e., a specific service provider system 190) and user devices 103 exceeds a threshold amount (e.g., approximately 300 k of traffic). For a large organization, this may further reduce the list of SaaS providers to evaluate from a number that is on the order of thousands of SaaS providers to, for example, a number that might approach or be on the order of one thousand or so.

(71) Analysis computing system 120 may, from the remaining list of SaaS providers, identify SaaS providers having proxy log data that exceeds a certain threshold (303). For instance, still referring to FIG. 1 and FIG. 3, analysis computing system 120 filters the list of SaaS providers to limit the list to those where the amount of session log data associated with sessions between each such SaaS

site (i.e., a specific service provider system **190**) and user devices **103** during a specific time period exceeds a threshold amount (e.g., approximately 50 k of session data or so). For a large organization, this may further reduce the list from a size on the order of 1000 to approximately a few hundred SaaS providers (i.e., a few hundred service provider systems **190**).

(72) Analysis computing system **120** may, for each remaining SaaS provider, extract URL path data from the sessions logs (**304**). For instance, still referring to FIG. **1** and FIG. **3**, analysis computing system **120** extracts URL path information from the session data associated with communications between user devices **103** and each service provider system **190** corresponding to one of the SaaS providers that remains on the list. Analysis computing system **120** processes each URL to identify certain components of the URL, such as stems and objects. FIG. **3** illustrates two examples of such URL data: URL data **310A** and URL data **310B**. URL data **310A** includes a list of URLs associated with a SaaS site that might be located at the abc.com domain. As shown in FIG. **3**, a reference to stem **311A** may refer to that portion of a specific URL that follows the domain, but precedes the name of a document that might be associated with a given URL. A reference to an object **312A** may refer to that portion of the URL that generally corresponds to the filename or data file associated with the URL. URL data **310B** is another example (omitting the protocol and domain names), showing those portions of three example URLs that correspond to stems **311B** and objects **312B**.

(73) Analysis computing system **120** analyzes URL data **310** by counting the number of stems **311** (stems **311A** and stems **311B**). For example, it has been observed that common unique paths, or those having the same stem information, tend to have the highest concentration of document storage at SaaS systems. Therefore, counting unique path stems (e.g., the stem “freehand/document/” or the stem “file uploads/”) may tend to yield directories or paths on a given service provider system **190** that are more likely to correspond to data being stored at that service provider system **190**.

(74) To isolate those URLs that are more likely to yield relevant data, analysis computing system **120** tabulates the occurrence counts of each stem, as illustrated in table **330** of FIG. **3**. Table **330** is a list of stems for a given SaaS provider (i.e., one of service provider systems **190**), along with an occurrence count for each of the stems. Table **330** indicates that stem “state/delta/” has only 3 occurrences, which may mean that log data associated with this SaaS provider included URLs matching this stem only 3 times. Stem “state/xyzbank/,” on the other hand, had more than 87 thousand occurrences, which may mean that the same log data included URLs matching this stem more than 87 thousand times. Analysis computing system **120** may identify those stems with the highest occurrence counts (i.e., such as “state/xyzbank/” and “state/irs-gov/”) as being most appropriate for further analysis. Analysis computing system **120** generates a list of URLs that tends to include URLs having stems with high occurrence counts. Analysis computing system **120** generates path data that includes these URLs, and the resulting list is a subset of the full set of path data (e.g., see path data **136** shown in FIG. **2**).

(75) Analysis computing system **120** may automate retrieval of the data associated with the extracted URL path, and enable analysis of data successfully received at the corresponding URLs (**305**). For instance, again referring to FIG. **1** and FIG. **3**, analysis computing system **120** outputs the subset of path data (described above) to collection computing system **170** and causes collection computing system **170** to attempt to access each URL in the list of URLs. Collection computing system **170** analyzes the responses and makes an assessment about whether the response includes data and/or whether it includes data that might be characterized as private, sensitive, confidential, and/or otherwise non-public information. In some examples, collection computing system **170** may attempt to access data at all of the URLs corresponding to the high occurrence count stem (e.g., all 87,141 of the URLs using stem “state/xyzbank/”). In other examples, however, collection computing system **170** might attempt to access only a high or large sample of those URLs, which may be enough to make assessments about whether the service provider system **190** associated with table **330** is properly maintaining the sensitivity of data. For example, if collection computing

system **170** accesses **30,000** URLs using the stem “state/xyzbank/” and is unable to find any sensitive data, collection computing system **170** may conclude that the corresponding service provider system **190** is likely properly maintaining the confidentiality of data stored at all or the vast majority of the locations that use that stem.

(76) After performing collection and analysis operations, collection computing system **170** may report its findings to analysis computing system **120**. Analysis computing system **120** may act on the reported findings received from collection computing system **170**.

(77) In some examples, and as described herein, collection computing system **170** may collect data from service provider systems **190** using URLs that correspond to or that are the same as those identified in proxy data, session data, or other log data (generally “interaction data”) obtained from cloud access security broker system **108** and/or content system **104**. In other words, collection computing system **170** may simply use the same URLs that were previously used by one or more of user devices **103** within enterprise network **102** to store or access data at service provider systems **190**. However, in some cases it may be possible to leverage the interaction data stored by enterprise network **102** to gain further insights about how one or more of service provider systems **190** store data. For example, it may be possible to identify other URLs that can be used in data access attempts performed by collection computing system **170**, where such other URLs might not directly correspond to those used by user devices **103** during prior sessions with service provider systems **190**.

(78) For example, note that the URLs illustrated within URL data **310A** of FIG. **3** seem to have some regularity, such that the illustrated URLs in URL data **310A** not only have the same stem **311A**, but also, each of the objects **312A** are the same length (i.e., 6 characters in length). Analysis computing system **120** may identify such patterns or regularity in objects **312** included within various instances of URL data **310**, and determine that the service provider system **190** associated with such URL data **310** stores data using a predictable pattern. In the example of URL data **310A**, data appears to be stored using stem **311A** and objects **312A**, where those objects **312A** are simply randomly generated 6-character strings. Analysis computing system **120** may recognize this pattern and use the pattern to generate a comprehensive list of all possible URLs stored at locations that use this common stem **311A** of URL data **310A**. To generate such a list, analysis computing system **120** generates a list of all possible 6-character strings and uses such strings as objects to pair with stem **311A**. The resulting list of URLs might be quite large, but it would be finite. And for an automated system, as described herein, a significant portion of the URLs on such a list could be evaluated within a reasonable time frame.

(79) In such an example, analysis computing system **120** generates a list of URLs, communicates the list to collection computing system **170**, and causes collection computing system **170** to perform systematic and automated collection and analysis operations with respect to a specific service provider system **190** that uses an identifiable pattern to store data. Such collection and analysis operations may yield additional information and insights about the data storage practices by each of the corresponding SaaS provider, beyond what might be gained by simply accessing specific identifiable URLs manifested in interaction data derived from communication sessions between user devices **103** of enterprise network **102** and service provider systems **190**.

(80) FIG. **4** is a flow diagram illustrating operations performed by an example assessment computing system in accordance with one or more aspects of the present disclosure. FIG. **4** is described below within the context of assessment computing system **110** of FIG. **1**. In other examples, operations described in FIG. **4** may be performed by one or more other components, modules, systems, or devices. Further, in other examples, operations described in connection with FIG. **4** may be merged, performed in a difference sequence, omitted, or may encompass additional operations not specifically illustrated or described.

(81) In the process illustrated in FIG. **4**, and in accordance with one or more aspects of the present disclosure, assessment computing system **110** may collect information about interactions with one

or more service provider systems **190** (**401** of FIG. **4**). For example, with reference to FIG. **1**, analysis computing system **120** of assessment computing system **110** outputs a signal over private network **101**. Content system **104** detects a signal over private network **101** and determines that the signal corresponds to a request for information about communications between user devices **103** and service provider systems **190**. Content system **104** outputs a signal over private network **101**. Analysis computing system **120** detects a signal over private network **101** and determines that the signal includes information about communications that have previously taken place between user devices **103** and service provider systems **190**.

(82) Assessment computing system **110** may identify network paths (**402**). For example, again referring to FIG. **1**, analysis computing system **120** analyzes the information received from content system **104** and identifies URLs, URIs, and/or network path information associated with content stored to or accessed at service provider systems **190** by one or more user devices **103**. Analysis computing system **120** may extract stem and object information from each of the URLs and perform an analysis to identify those URLs having commonly-occurring stems (stems that are present in multiple URL strings), such as in the manner described in connection with FIG. **3**. Analysis computing system **120** may also select a subset of the URLs using the URLs having more commonly-occurring stems (or the most commonly-occurring stems). Analysis computing system **120** may select such a subset in order to limit the amount of processing and network traffic that might be associated with evaluating the path information.

(83) Assessment computing system **110** may request data from one or more service provider systems **190** (**403**). For example, in FIG. **1**, analysis computing system **120** of assessment computing system **110** outputs a signal over private network **101** and public network **150**. Collection computing system **170** of assessment computing system **110** receives a signal and determines that the signal includes a list of URLs that can be used to evaluate data maintenance practices of one or more service provider systems **190**. Collection computing system **170** uses the URLs to request data from at least one of service provider systems **190**. In one example, collection computing system **170** outputs request **188A** over public network **150**, seeking to access data at one of the URLs in the list of URLs received from analysis computing system **120**. Since collection computing system **170** is not on private network **101**, collection computing system **170** is making the request over public network **150**. In the example being described, collection computing system **170** does not provide authentication credentials any of service provider systems **190**, and is therefore requesting data (through request **188A**) with the access rights of an anonymous computing device that merely has access to public network **150**.

(84) Assessment computing system **110** may receive a response to the request from a service provider system **190** (**404**). For example, again with reference to FIG. **1** and in the example being described, service provider system **190A** detects a signal over public network **150**. Service provider system **190A** determines that the signal corresponds to request **188A**. Service provider system **190A** outputs a responsive signal over public network **150**. Collection computing system **170** of assessment computing system **110** detects a signal over public network **150** and determines that the signal corresponds to response **182A** from service provider system **190A**.

(85) Assessment computing system **110** may determine whether response **182A** includes sensitive data (**405**). For example, collection computing system **170** analyzes response **182A** to determine whether it includes any data or any meaningful data. If response **182A** does not include any data, or is simply a denial of the request for data, collection computing system **170** concludes that no sensitive data is available at the requested URL. Collection computing system **170** may also conclude that for the data at the requested URL, service provider system **190A** appears to be properly protecting the privacy and/or confidentiality of any sensitive data that might be stored at that URL (NO path from **405**). Assessment computing system **110** may then continue processing other URLs by issuing new requests to service provider systems **190**.

(86) If collection computing system **170** determines that response **182A** does include data,

collection computing system **170** analyzes the data to determine whether it includes sensitive information. In some examples, collection computing system **170** may apply a machine learning model to make such an assessment. If the model determines that no sensitive data is included within response **182A**, collection computing system **170** concludes that for the specified URL, no sensitive data is being improperly published by service provider system **190A**. Collection computing system **170** of assessment computing system **110** may continue evaluating other URLs in the list (NO path from **405**). In some examples, if response **182A** is benign (contains no sensitive data), assessment operations performed by collection computing system **170** may be adjusted to avoid reassessing the same URL for some period of time in the future (e.g., within the next 60 days).

(87) If collection computing system **170** of assessment computing system **110** determines that response **182A** does include sensitive data, assessment computing system **110** may take action (**406** and YES path from **405**). For example, collection computing system **170** may report, to analysis computing system **120**, information about URLs and/or service provider systems **190** that are making sensitive data publicly available on public network **150**. Analysis computing system **120** may evaluate the reporting and take action, such as by sending information to appropriate personnel (e.g., administrators of enterprise network **102**), by limiting access to one or more service provider systems **190**, or by taking other actions. In some examples, limiting access to one or more service provider systems **190** may involve analysis computing system **120** configuring cloud access security broker system **108** to restrict access by user devices **103** to one or more of service provider systems **190**. In some examples, whether or not sensitive data is detected, the machine learning model may be retrained using response **182A** as an additional training example.

(88) For processes, apparatuses, and other examples or illustrations described herein, including in any flowcharts or flow diagrams, certain operations, acts, steps, or events included in any of the techniques described herein can be performed in a different sequence, may be added, merged, or left out altogether (e.g., not all described acts or events are necessary for the practice of the techniques). Moreover, in certain examples, operations, acts, steps, or events may be performed concurrently, e.g., through multi-threaded processing, interrupt processing, or multiple processors, rather than sequentially. Further certain operations, acts, steps, or events may be performed automatically even if not specifically identified as being performed automatically. Also, certain operations, acts, steps, or events described as being performed automatically may be alternatively not performed automatically, but rather, such operations, acts, steps, or events may be, in some examples, performed in response to input or another event.

(89) The disclosures of all publications, patents, and patent applications referred to herein are each hereby incorporated by reference in their entireties. To the extent that any such disclosure material that is incorporated by reference conflicts with the instant disclosure, the instant disclosure shall control.

(90) For ease of illustration, only a limited number of devices (e.g., analysis computing system **120**, collection computing system **170**, service provider systems **190**, cloud access security broker system **108**, content system **104**, as well as others) are shown within the Figures and/or in other illustrations referenced herein. However, techniques in accordance with one or more aspects of the present disclosure may be performed with many more of such systems, components, devices, modules, and/or other items, and collective references to such systems, components, devices, modules, and/or other items may represent any number of such systems, components, devices, modules, and/or other items.

(91) The Figures included herein each illustrate at least one example implementation of an aspect of this disclosure. The scope of this disclosure is not, however, limited to such implementations. Accordingly, other example or alternative implementations of systems, methods or techniques described herein, beyond those illustrated in the Figures, may be appropriate in other instances. Such implementations may include a subset of the devices and/or components included in the

Figures and/or may include additional devices and/or components not shown in the Figures.

(92) The detailed description set forth above is intended as a description of various configurations and is not intended to represent the only configurations in which the concepts described herein may be practiced. The detailed description includes specific details for the purpose of providing a sufficient understanding of the various concepts. However, these concepts may be practiced without these specific details. In some instances, well-known structures and components are shown in block diagram form in the referenced figures in order to avoid obscuring such concepts.

(93) Accordingly, although one or more implementations of various systems, devices, and/or components may be described with reference to specific Figures, such systems, devices, and/or components may be implemented in a number of different ways. For instance, one or more devices illustrated in the Figures herein as separate devices may alternatively be implemented as a single device; one or more components illustrated as separate components may alternatively be implemented as a single component. Also, in some examples, one or more devices illustrated in the Figures herein as a single device may alternatively be implemented as multiple devices; one or more components illustrated as a single component may alternatively be implemented as multiple components. Each of such multiple devices and/or components may be directly coupled via wired or wireless communication and/or remotely coupled via one or more networks. Also, one or more devices or components that may be illustrated in various Figures herein may alternatively be implemented as part of another device or component not shown in such Figures. In this and other ways, some of the functions described herein may be performed via distributed processing by two or more devices or components.

(94) Further, certain operations, techniques, features, and/or functions may be described herein as being performed by specific components, devices, and/or modules. In other examples, such operations, techniques, features, and/or functions may be performed by different components, devices, or modules. Accordingly, some operations, techniques, features, and/or functions that may be described herein as being attributed to one or more components, devices, or modules may, in other examples, be attributed to other components, devices, and/or modules, even if not specifically described herein in such a manner.

(95) Although specific advantages have been identified in connection with descriptions of some examples, various other examples may include some, none, or all of the enumerated advantages. Other advantages, technical or otherwise, may become apparent to one of ordinary skill in the art from the present disclosure. Further, although specific examples have been disclosed herein, aspects of this disclosure may be implemented using any number of techniques, whether currently known or not, and accordingly, the present disclosure is not limited to the examples specifically described and/or illustrated in this disclosure.

(96) In one or more examples, the functions described may be implemented in hardware, software, firmware, or any combination thereof. If implemented in software, the functions may be stored, as one or more instructions or code, on and/or transmitted over a computer-readable medium and executed by a hardware-based processing unit. Computer-readable media may include computer-readable storage media, which corresponds to a tangible medium such as data storage media, or communication media including any medium that facilitates transfer of a computer program from one place to another (e.g., pursuant to a communication protocol). In this manner, computer-readable media generally may correspond to (1) tangible computer-readable storage media, which is non-transitory or (2) a communication medium such as a signal or carrier wave. Data storage media may be any available media that can be accessed by one or more computers or one or more processors to retrieve instructions, code and/or data structures for implementation of the techniques described in this disclosure. A computer program product may include a computer-readable medium.

(97) By way of example, and not limitation, such computer-readable storage media can include RAM, ROM, EEPROM, or optical disk storage, magnetic disk storage, or other magnetic storage

devices, flash memory, or any other medium that can be used to store desired program code in the form of instructions or data structures and that can be accessed by a computer. Also, any connection may properly be termed a computer-readable medium. For example, if instructions are transmitted from a website, server, or other remote source using a wired (e.g., coaxial cable, fiber optic cable, twisted pair) or wireless (e.g., infrared, radio, and microwave) connection, then the wired or wireless connection is included in the definition of medium. It should be understood, however, that computer-readable storage media and data storage media do not include connections, carrier waves, signals, or other transient media, but are instead directed to non-transient, tangible storage media.

(98) Instructions may be executed by one or more processors, such as one or more digital signal processors (DSPs), general purpose microprocessors, application specific integrated circuits (ASICs), field programmable logic arrays (FPGAs), or other equivalent integrated or discrete logic circuitry. Accordingly, the terms “processor” or “processing circuitry” as used herein may each refer to any of the foregoing structure or any other structure suitable for implementation of the techniques described. In addition, in some examples, the functionality described may be provided within dedicated hardware and/or software modules. Also, the techniques could be fully implemented in one or more circuits or logic elements.

(99) The techniques of this disclosure may be implemented in a wide variety of devices or apparatuses, including a wireless handset, a mobile or non-mobile computing device, a wearable or non-wearable computing device, an integrated circuit (IC) or a set of ICs (e.g., a chip set). Various components, modules, or units are described in this disclosure to emphasize functional aspects of devices configured to perform the disclosed techniques, but do not necessarily require realization by different hardware units. Rather, as described above, various units may be combined in a hardware unit or provided by a collection of interoperating hardware units, including one or more processors as described above, in conjunction with suitable software and/or firmware.

Claims

1. A method comprising: collecting, by a computing system, information about interactions with a service provider computing system, wherein the interactions with the service provider computing system are based on activity of user devices on a private network that are authenticated to access data at the service provider computing system; identifying, by the computing system and based on the information about the interactions, a plurality of network paths, each associated with a data object accessed by at least one of the user devices at the service provider computing system; requesting, by the computing system using a device not on the private network and not authenticated to access data at the service provider computing system and based on the plurality of network paths, data from the service provider computing system; responsive to requesting the data, receiving, by the computing system, a response; determining, by the computing system and based on the response, whether the response includes sensitive information; and taking action by the computing system based on whether the response includes sensitive data.

2. The method of claim 1, wherein collecting the information about the interactions includes: accessing activity log information that is maintained by the private network and is associated with interactions by the user devices with the service provider computing system.

3. The method of claim 1, wherein identifying the plurality of network paths includes: identifying a plurality of stems, each included within a network path of the plurality of network paths; and determining an occurrence count associated with each of the plurality of stems.

4. The method of claim 3, wherein identifying the plurality of network paths further includes: identifying a subset of the plurality of stems based on the occurrence count associated with each of the plurality of stems; and generating the plurality of network paths based on the subset of the plurality of stems.

5. The method of claim 1, further comprising: training a machine learning model to identify data

that includes sensitive information.

6. The method of claim 5, wherein determining whether the response includes sensitive data includes: applying the machine learning model to the response.

7. The method of claim 1, wherein the service provider computing system is a first service provider computing system, wherein the plurality of network paths is a first plurality of network paths, and wherein the response is a first response, the method further comprising: collecting, by the computing system, information about interactions with a second service provider computing system, wherein the interactions with the second service provider computing system are based on the activity of the user devices on the private network; identifying, by the computing system and based on the information about the interactions with the second service provider computing system, a second plurality of network paths, each associated with a data object accessed by at least one of the user devices at the second service provider computing system; requesting, from the second service provider computing system and based on the second plurality of network paths, data from the second service provider computing system; responsive to requesting the data from the second service provider computing system, receiving, by the computing system, a second response; and determining, by the computing system and based on the second response, whether the second response includes sensitive information.

8. The method of claim 1, wherein the computing system comprises: an analysis computing system that is on the private network; and a collection computing system that is not on the private network.

9. The method of claim 8, wherein collecting the information about the interactions includes: collecting, by the analysis computing system, the information about the interactions.

10. The method of claim 8, wherein requesting the data from the service provider computing system includes: requesting, by the collection computing system, the data from the service provider computing system.

11. The method of claim 8, wherein taking action includes: configuring a cloud access security broker, by the analysis computing system, to restrict access by the user devices to the service provider computing system.

12. A system comprising an analysis computing system and a collection computing system, wherein the analysis computing system is on a private network, and the collection computing system is not on the private network, and wherein the analysis computing system comprises processing circuitry and a storage device, and wherein the processing circuitry has access to the storage device and is configured to: collect information about interactions with a service provider computing system, wherein the interactions with the service provider computing system are based on activity of user devices on the private network that are authenticated to access data at the service provider computing system; identify, based on the information about the interactions, a plurality of network paths, each associated with a data object accessed at the service provider computing system; enable the collection computing system to: request, using a device not on the private network and not authenticated to access data at the service provider computing system and based on the plurality of network paths, data from the service provider computing system, receive a response, and determine, based on the response, whether the response includes sensitive information; and take action based on whether the response includes sensitive data.

13. The system of claim 12, wherein to collect the information about the interactions, the analysis computing system is further configured to: access activity log information that is maintained by the private network.

14. The system of claim 12, wherein to identify the plurality of network paths, the analysis computing system is further configured to: identify a plurality of stems, each included within a network path of the plurality of network paths; and determine an occurrence count associated with each of the plurality of stems.

15. The system of claim 14, wherein to identify the plurality of network paths, the analysis computing system is further configured to: identify a subset of the plurality of stems on the

occurrence count associated with each of the plurality of stems; generate the plurality of network paths based on the subset of the plurality of stems.

16. The system of claim 12, wherein the analysis computing system is further configured to: train a machine learning model to identify data that includes sensitive information.

17. The system of claim 16, wherein to determine whether the response includes sensitive data, the collection computing system is configured to: apply the machine learning model to the response.

18. The system of claim 12, wherein the service provider computing system is a first service provider computing system, wherein the plurality of network paths is a first plurality of network paths, wherein the response is a first response, and wherein the analysis computing system is further configured to: collect information about interactions with a second service provider computing system, wherein the interactions with the second service provider computing system are based on the activity of the user devices on the private network; and identify, based on the information about the interactions with the second service provider computing system, a second plurality of network paths, each associated with a data object accessed at the second service provider computing system.

19. The system of claim 18, wherein the analysis computing system is further configured to enable the collection computing system to: request, from the second service provider computing system and based on the second plurality of network paths, data from the second service provider computing system; receive a second response; determine, based on the second response, whether the second response includes sensitive information.

20. A non-transitory computer-readable storage medium comprising instructions that, when executed, configure processing circuitry of a computing system to: collect information about interactions with a service provider computing system, wherein the interactions with the service provider computing system are based on activity of user devices on a private network that are authenticated to access data at the service provider computing system; identify, based on the information about the interactions, a plurality of network paths, each associated with a data object accessed at the service provider computing system; enable a collection computing system to request data from the service provider computing system using a device not on the private network and not authenticated to access data at the service provider computing system, receive a response, and determine whether the response includes sensitive information; and take action based on whether the response includes sensitive data.
